



Sen. Maggie Hassan, D-N.H., asked whether more safeguards should be put in place on U.S. research grants to gain more insight into how they are being used. SAMUEL CORUM / GETTY IMAGES

News

Scientists argue over the origins of COVID-19 before Senate panel

Microbiology and biodefense experts continued to wrangle over whether COVID-19 emerged from a laboratory leak or was passed to humans through exposure from another animal.

JENNIFER SHUTT, MISSOURI INDEPENDENT | JUNE 20, 2024

HOMELAND SECURITY



Scientists debated the origins of COVID-19 on Tuesday, trading barbs over whether the bulk of evidence available points to a natural spillover event from a wild animal or a virus designed in a lab and then let loose through an inadvertent leak.

The hearing in front of the Senate Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs Committee was part of ongoing efforts in Congress to apply the lessons learned during the pandemic to prevent or blunt the next outbreak.

Gregory Koblentz, associate professor and director of the Biodefense Graduate Program at George Mason University in Virginia, said during the [two-hour hearing](#) that debate continues in the scientific community about the origins.

“The possibility that SARS-CoV-2 was deliberately developed as a biological weapon has been unanimously rejected by all U.S. intelligence agencies,” Koblentz testified. “While the intelligence community is divided on the origin of the pandemic, most of the agencies have determined that the virus was not genetically engineered.”

Residents in Wuhan, China, were first diagnosed with “an atypical pneumonia-like illness” in December 2019, according to a [COVID-19 timeline](#) from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

Initial cases all appeared linked to the Huanan Seafood Wholesale Market at the time, though there has since been much speculation about the types of research taking place at the Wuhan Institute of Virology.

accident can't be ruled out at this time.

The lack of transparency and data from the Chinese government has significantly hindered scientists' efforts to unify around the origin of COVID-19, he said.

Scientists battle over lab vs. spillover

Richard Ebright, board of governors professor of chemistry and chemical biology and laboratory director at the Waksman Institute of Microbiology at Rutgers University in New Jersey, testified he believes a "large preponderance of evidence indicates SARS-CoV-2, the virus that causes COVID-19, entered humans through a research incident."

Ebright also leveled criticism at fellow panelist Robert Garry, who, along with a handful of co-authors, [published an opinion article](#) in the journal nature medicine in March 2020, titled "The proximal origin of SARS-CoV-2."

In the commentary, Garry and the other scientists wrote, "we do not believe that any type of laboratory-based scenario is plausible."

Ebright said during Tuesday's hearing that the opinion article represented "scientific misconduct up to and including fraud," a characterization that Garry rejected during the hearing.

"The authors were stating their opinion, but that opinion was not well-founded," Ebright said. "In March of 2020, there was no basis to state that as a conclusion, as opposed to simply being a hypothesis."

Garry, professor and associate dean of the School of Medicine at Tulane University in Louisiana, argued on behalf of the spillover event during the hearing, testifying that the virus likely didn't move directly from a bat to humans, but went to an unidentified intermediary animal.

"The bat coronaviruses are viruses that are spread by the gastrointestinal route," Garry said. "For a virus like this to become a respiratory virus — it's just going to require too many mutations, too many changes for a bat virus to spill directly over to a human being. That could only really happen in nature with replication through an intermediate animal."

Garry also defended gain-of-function research during the hearing, arguing that it has had some beneficial impact, though he noted that it does need "appropriate safeguards and restrictions."

pandemic. The American Society for Microbiology [defines](#) it as techniques "used in research to alter the function of an organism in such a way that it is able to do more than it used to do."

When research is "responsibly performed" on highly transmissible and pathogenic viruses, it can lead to advances in public health and national security, Garry testified.

"Without gain-of-function research, we'd have no Tamiflu. Without gain-of-function research, we wouldn't have a vaccine to prevent cancer caused by infection by the human papilloma virus," Garry said. "And without gain-of-function research, we won't be able to identify how novel viruses infect us. And if we don't know how they infect us, we cannot develop appropriate treatments and cures for the next potential pandemic creating virus."

Oversight of funding, research

Sen. Maggie Hassan, D-N.H., raised several questions about whether there's enough oversight of how the United States spends research dollars as well as what mechanisms are in place to monitor how private entities conduct certain types of research.

"While their research has the potential to cure diseases and boost our economy, unless they accept federal funding, there is very little federal oversight to ensure that private labs are engaged in safe and ethical research," she said.

Koblentz from George Mason University said there is much less oversight of biosafety and biosecurity for private research facilities that don't receive federal funding.

"In order to expand the scope of oversight to all privately funded research, [it] would require legislative action," Koblentz said.

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regardless of the source of funding.

“At the end of the day, it shouldn’t matter where the funding comes from in terms of making sure this research is being done safely, securely and responsibly,” Koblentz said.

Sen. Rand Paul, R-Ky., ranking member on the committee, said the panel will hold an upcoming hearing specifically on gain-of-function research, including what steps Congress should take to ensure it doesn’t put the public at risk.

The next pandemic

Committee Chairman Gary Peters, D-Mich., said during the hearing that lawmakers “must learn from the challenges faced during this pandemic to ensure we can better protect Americans from future potential biological incidents.”

“Our government needs the flexibility to determine the origins of naturally occurring outbreaks, as well as potential outbreaks that could arise from mistakes or malicious intent,” Peters said.

Sen. Mitt Romney, R-Utah, after listening to some of the debate, expressed exasperation that so much attention is going toward what caused the last pandemic and not on how to prepare for the next one.

“Given the fact that it could have been either, we know what action we ought to take to protect from either,” Romney said. “And so why there’s so much passion around that makes me think it’s more political than scientific, but maybe I’m wrong.”

The United States, he said, shouldn’t be funding gain-of-function research and should “insist” that anyone who receives federal funding follow the standards of the International Organization for Standardization.

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New survey data from The Partnership for Public Service found that only 23% of respondents trust the federal government. SHIRONOSOV / GETTY IMAGES

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Schedule F looms over trust in government summit

New survey data from the Partnership for Public Service shows there is strong bipartisan support among the public for a nonpartisan civil service.

SEAN MICHAEL NEWHOUSE | JUNE 11, 2024

SCHEDULE F CIVIL SERVICE



The vast majority of surveyed Americans oppose Donald Trump’s plans to remove job protections for thousands of civil servants, according to [poll data](#) released by a nonpartisan good government organization this week.

“Americans expect a government that serves their needs ahead of any political interest. Rebuilding trust in government requires us to support — not weaken — our nonpartisan civil service system,” Lindsay Laferriere, a director at the Partnership for Public Service, said at an event Tuesday focused on building trust in the government. “There are many ways to improve government. The Partnership has been at this a long time and we have lots of ideas, but giving the president and his appointees more latitude to fire civil servants and hire their replacements based on political loyalty is not the answer.”

Trump, the likely Republican nominee for president, has campaigned on [reviving Schedule F](#), a failed effort of his administration to convert tens of thousands of federal workers in “policy-related” positions out of the competitive service. This would effectively make them at-will employees.

The Partnership’s report found that 87% of Americans surveyed — including 88% of Democrats and 87% of Republicans — agree that having a nonpartisan civil service is important to a strong democracy.

Likewise, 95% of respondents said that civil servants should be hired and promoted based on merit rather than their political beliefs, and 72% disagreed with the idea that presidents should be able to fire “any civil servants that they choose for any reason.”

“The concern is that [Schedule F] is viewed as sort of inside baseball [and] not relevant to people's daily lives when, in fact, it has profound significance for the quality of services and the capability of our government to protect us and make us safe,” said Max Stier, the Partnership’s president.

Schedule F supporters have said it’s necessary to more easily remove poor performers as well as government workers who disagree with the policy decisions of their bosses.

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undermine policies they disagree with, including 75% of Republicans and 55% of Democrats.

The Partnership and Impact Research administered the poll from March 25 through April 1 to 800 adults nationwide. Responses were weighted based on the demographic makeup of the U.S.

Notably, the report found that only 23% of respondents trust the federal government. In fact, trust in the federal government since 2022 declined across all demographic groups in the survey, including based on political affiliation, race and ethnicity, sex and age.

However almost half of respondents reported that their own experiences with the federal government, such as when filing taxes or going through airport security, have been mostly positive. But just 28% agreed that was true for most Americans.

“What was new about our findings is that when you asked about individual federal agencies, or civil servants, people had a lot more positive impressions of those folks. And those are the people that deliver services and serve the public every day,” Laferriere said. “So there seems to be a bit of a disconnect. People like the federal employees who work in government, but they don't trust government overall.”

Author Michael Lewis, who wrote [a book about the federal bureaucracy under the Trump administration](#), argued at the event that in order to rebuild trust in the government the stories and successes of its employees must be told. He equated doing so with changing a stereotype.

“It's very easy to cling to those stereotypes when you don't have actual personal interaction with the object of the bigotry or the stereotype. The minute you're in a foxhole with them, the minute you're in a basketball game with them, the minute you're just in a dinner with someone who you’ve been stereotyping, you realize, ‘Oh no. Stereotype wrong,’ or that it's just silly,” he said. “And it's a stereotype we need to break.” [G](#)

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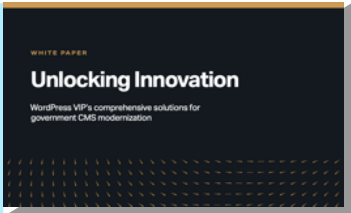
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